

Filippo Brunelleschi

The Florentine Filippo Brunelleschi (1377–1446) is widely considered the first Renaissance architect, although his early works were still related to Gothic designs. Trained as a goldsmith in Florence, he travelled to Rome to study ancient buildings, and began working as an architect from that time. One of his greatest feats was the massive dome of Florence Cathedral, the Santa Maria del Fiore, or Duomo (c.1420–36). It was a remarkable feat of engineering incorporating not one, but two domes, one inside the other. He even had to invent special machines to hoist each section into place. The building's plain exterior includes a series of blind arches, while the interior is composed of flat surfaces and Doric, Ionic and Corinthian columns. With their apparent simplicity, Brunelleschi's designs evoke a sense of rationalism and proportion; for instance, his Hospital of the Innocents (1419, opposite) is based on a modular cube. The Basilica of San Lorenzo (1420–69) links elements of local building traditions with the architecture of ancient Rome.

